

The Political Consequences of “Source Country” Operations: Evidence from Crop Eradication in Mexico*

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Abstract

Drug-producing, or source countries, routinely destroy illegal crops under international pressure to curb drug supply, despite the high costs imposed on crop-growing communities. I study the domestic political consequences of crop eradication in Mexico. The Mexican army incinerates thousands of fields yearly in a context shaped by US counternarcotics pressure. I argue that, for the marginalized communities that bear its costs, eradication erodes trust in the federal government and depresses turnout. To test, I build a novel precinct-level measure from 50,000 satellite-detected fields and NASA fire data. I compare precincts where detected fields were eradicated before elections to similar precincts in the same military zone with comparable pre-election detected cultivation. I show that eradication depresses turnout and, exploiting the timing of a national survey, erodes trust in federal security institutions. International pressure that keeps coercive policy off the electoral menu may weaken accountability by pushing affected citizens toward political withdrawal.

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For more than six decades, the United States has funded and promoted the destruction and interdiction of illegal substances abroad as part of its drug abuse prevention strategy (Bagley, 2015; Cedillo, 2021). Such “source country” counternarcotics tactics are motivated by the idea that reducing the supply of imported drugs should, in turn, mechanically reduce consumption (Isacson, 2015; Tokatlian, 2015). To incentivize foreign governments to carry out these costly operations, the United States conditions millions of dollars in aid to major drug-producing or drug transit countries on an annual certification extended only to those that “cooperated fully with the United States in drug control efforts” (Storrs, 2002). While source-country operations are ineffective at reducing supply in the long run (Mejía, Restrepo, & Roza, 2015; Moreno Sanchez, Kraybill, & Thompson, 2003; Prem, Vargas, & Mejía, 2023), drug-producing countries gain favor with the US by consistently carrying them out, thus facilitating yearly certification.

In this paper, I examine the domestic political consequences of a paradigmatic example of US-sponsored source country operations: illegal crop eradication in Mexico. Extant research has conceptualized law enforcement policy as endogenous to domestic politics, responding to electoral incentives and preexisting social inequalities (González & Mayka, 2022; Holland, 2013; Kronick, 2014; Magaloni, Franco-Vivanco, & Melo, 2020; Visconti, 2020). In contrast, conditional US aid incentivizes recipient governments to prioritize foreign over domestic security preferences. This dynamic is particularly salient in Latin America, where drug production and trafficking are closely monitored by the US (Drug Enforcement Administration, 2021). Indeed, of the 22 countries the US government identified as major drug transit or illegal drug-producing nations for fiscal year 2022, 17 are in Latin America or the Caribbean.¹

Drawing from ethnographic and journalistic sources, I argue that crop-growing communities experience eradication, carried out by the Mexican army, as the federal government behaving punitively towards them by interfering with their already precarious well-being (Alvarez, Gaussens, & Frissard, 2022; Álvarez Rodríguez, 2021b; Le Cour Grandmaison, 2021). As one poppy farmer

¹Presidential Determination on Major Drug Transit or Major Illicit Drug Producing Countries for Fiscal Year 2022. Available at [federalregister.gov](https://www.federalregister.gov).

in Guerrero's Sierra put it: "We are not the bad guys, we are the poor ones."² I conceptualize institutional trust as the belief that a representative government agent will tend to act in one's interest (Bhattacharya, Devinney, & Pillutla, 1998; Hardin, 2002) and follow work positing that the quality of interactions with state agents informs this belief (Abril, Norza, Perez-Vincent, Tobón, & Weintraub, 2024; G. Blair et al., 2021; Slough & Torreblanca, 2024). The coercive nature of eradication-spurred interactions should therefore lead people to update their beliefs about the trustworthiness of the federal government and the bureaucracies responsible for eradicating illegal crops downwards.

I further expect eradication to depress turnout in federal elections rather than engendering electoral backlash. While aggrieved eradicated-crop growers may be motivated to incentivize change in federal counternarcotics policy through electoral means, they lack the opportunity to do so. The importance of US security aid, coupled with the political weakness of crop-growing communities, effectively excludes eradication from the menu of reformable policy. For the federal government, the financial benefits of receiving foreign aid outweigh the costs of alienating small, poor, crop-growing communities. Elite interviews with high-ranking federal politicians in the executive and legislative branches confirm this political calculus. An ex-presidential Chief of Staff explained, "In high-level decision-making, the bilateral relationship and systemic benefits were prioritized over micro-level impact. These impacts were recognized but managed as collateral damage."³ Thus, no political force has an incentive to propose reforming counternarcotics policy, as doing so risks losing the foreign country's favor and financial backing. Unable to channel their discontent through vote choice, I expect residents of eradicated communities to be more likely to abstain from voting.

To test these hypotheses, I develop a novel precinct-level measure of eradication. The army most commonly destroys illegal fields through incineration. Accordingly, my measure integrates satellite imagery of over 50,000 illegal crop fields detected by the Mexican army with NASA fire records that indicate the timing and location of field incinerations. Each season, the army detects more fields than it can eradicate. I therefore compare electoral precincts where the army eradicated

²Jan Martínez Ahrens, "La ley del opio en las montañas de Guerrero," *El País*, June 19, 2016.

³Interview with the author, May 2025.

detected fields with those where it detected fields but did not eradicate them, conditional on the detected fields being comparable in size, within the same military zone and detected during the same election year, and among precincts with similar prior histories of cultivation and eradication. To reduce model dependence and ensure covariate overlap, I pre-process the sample using entropy balancing (Hainmueller, 2012) on pre-election satellite-detected fields, schooling, and employment share. I supplement the precinct-level analysis with a municipal-level analysis that uses official eradication records and leverages within-municipality variation in participation in four elections for identification.

First, the results show that eradication reduces trust in the federal security apparatus. Leveraging the timing of survey collection across seven waves of an annual nationally representative survey and official eradication data published by the army at the municipality level, I show that rural dwellers in municipalities eradicated before survey collection report significantly lower trust in the army, the navy, and the federal police than individuals in comparable areas eradicated after survey collection. However, eradication does not affect trust in non-federal or non-policing institutions, nor does it affect trust among urban inhabitants who do not experience eradication operations personally.

Second, I show that eradication before a federal election lowers turnout. I compare precincts where the army eradicated detected fields with precincts in the same military zone that had a similar eradication history, where fields were detected in the same year but not eradicated. At the extensive margin, any episode of eradication reduces turnout by 2.4 percentage points. At the intensive margin, I find that the median eradicated precinct has 1.9 points, or 12% of a standard deviation, lower turnout. I complement the precinct results with a municipal panel of official army eradication records, comparing each municipality with itself in years when the army eradicated before the election and in years when it did so only after. The panel yields effects of similar sign and size. Going from no eradication to the median eradicated area or number of fields lowers municipal turnout by 1.3 to 1.5 points, on average.

A causal interpretation of the results requires that, within military zone, election year, and

eradication-history cells, and conditional on detected cultivation and baseline characteristics, precincts eradicated before the election would have had similar turnout to those eradicated later. A natural concern is that the army might choose where to eradicate in ways that covary with turnout. Four pieces of evidence speak against this possibility. First, I find that the army eventually eradicates most precincts where it detects illegal crops (Appendix Table A8). Second, I find that precincts eradicated before the election had turnout similar to comparison precincts in elections held before the satellite program began (Appendix Table A10). Third, within cells, geography explains less than 1% of the variation in which detected fields are eradicated (Appendix Table A13). Finally, in the municipal panel, only eradication in the cycle immediately preceding the election predicts lower turnout. Eradication before the previous election and eradication after the election do not (Table 2, columns 2 to 4).

Beyond selection, I assess whether migration, violence, or short-run income loss could instead explain the reduction in turnout after eradication, finding no evidence for any of these alternative channels. Using official address-change data, I show that eradication does not trigger differential out-migration between eradicated and control precincts. I also show that the effect of eradication on turnout holds when controlling for homicides. This finding is inconsistent with a violence-mediated mechanism where illegal crop destruction produces violent retaliation. Last, I leverage the 2018 poppy price collapse and examine changes in precinct-level nighttime luminosity. I show that the evidence is inconsistent with mechanically reducing turnout by making people resource-constrained. Instead, I cannot reject that eradication has the same short-run effect on turnout in high- and low-price years, and the point estimate is, if anything, larger when prices were lower. This pattern is consistent with eradication informing residents about federal policing priorities through an income shock on an asset that is fungible only in the mid- and long-run.

This paper contributes to three strands of research. First, it contributes to research on the domestic consequences of foreign aid by showing how conditional security assistance can undermine electoral accountability without weakening *de jure* democratic institutions. Existing work has largely studied the political effects of foreign aid, conceptualized as a transfer to recipient gov-

ernments or citizens (R. A. Blair & Roessler, 2021; Ping, Wang, & Chang, 2022). US counternarcotics assistance, however, conditions resources to recipient governments on sustained domestic law-enforcement efforts against drug production and trafficking. In Mexico, this gives the federal government an incentive to continue crop eradication despite its limited effectiveness and the costs it imposes on politically marginal communities. Results thus show that foreign assistance conditional on coercion against domestic constituencies can alienate domestic audiences from formal participation channels, eroding both trust and electoral participation.

Second, this paper extends research on the political consequences of crop eradication to Mexico. In so doing, it illustrates why the domestic costs of eradication need not translate into electoral opposition. Recent work in Colombia documents electoral backlash in areas targeted by eradication, as well as increased violence (Abadie, Acevedo, Kugler, & Vargas, 2014; Gélvez, 2024; Marín Llanes, 2022). I find instead that eradication reduces turnout in Mexico. I explain the discrepancy by treating participation as a decision made within a political opportunity structure that differs between the two countries. In Colombia, eradication is entwined with the armed conflict and has been formally contested in the electoral arena. In Mexico, the costs fall primarily on smallholder growers, eradication has persisted under governments led by three different parties, and growers are relatively few and poorly organized. The Mexican case separates the harm produced by eradication from affected communities' capacity to translate that harm into political opposition.

Third, this paper contributes to research on the political consequences of law enforcement in Latin America by showing that counternarcotics operations can change political behavior in the short run through a channel not mediated by criminal violence. Existing work in the region has studied the political consequences of criminal violence generated by counternarcotics enforcement (Dell, 2015; Trejo & Ley, 2020) and of prolonged exposure to militarized policing (Flores-Macías, 2018; Osorio, Schubiger, & Weintraub, 2021). Conversely, the direct, contemporaneous political consequences of individual enforcement operations have received less attention, in part because detailed records of law enforcement activity are rarely available. I overcome this constraint by

constructing a precinct-level measure of eradication from satellite imagery and NASA fire records, independent of government self-reports, and by building the first georeferenced map of Mexico's military zones and regions from freedom-of-information requests. These measures also provide a new empirical resource for studying the local political consequences of military counternarcotics enforcement in Mexico.

Conditional Security Aid as a Multiple Principals Problem

In traditional accounts of the dynamic production of policy, governments are electorally incentivized to be responsive to their domestic constituencies. For instance, observing crime and its punishment is posited to inform citizens about security policy and implementation, shaping their law enforcement preferences and participation decisions (Bateson, 2012; Kronick, 2014; Ley, 2018; Visconti, 2020). Citizens' preferences, in turn, influence which security policies politicians propose and enact as politicians cater to relevant constituencies by tailoring security policy to their tastes (González, 2020; Holland, 2013; Magaloni et al., 2020).

Conditional US aid, however, creates a channel parallel to electoral accountability through which foreign policy preferences influence domestic policy. Since 1986, the US has explicitly conditioned security aid on drug-producing countries' supply-reduction efforts, requiring presidential certification of their cooperation and potentially withholding 50% of security assistance from noncompliant countries (Storrs, 2003). This certification creates a powerful incentive for drug-producing and drug-transit countries to invest resources into drug interdiction and crop eradication, regardless of domestic preferences.⁴

Conditional security aid therefore places source-country governments between two principals with potentially different preferences: domestic voters and the US. When those preferences diverge, governments have stronger incentives to satisfy the principal whose support is more valu-

⁴Although the certification process became somewhat laxer in 2002, it remains a yearly hurdle for drug-producing countries, with drug interdiction activities serving as critical evidence of compliance. Presidential Determinations continue to highlight this pressure, citing Colombia's "extraordinary growth of coca cultivation" in 2018 or expressing concern that "illegal drug crops have expanded over successive years in Colombia, Mexico, and Afghanistan" in 2019. Presidential Determination on Major Drug Transit or Major Illicit Drug Producing Countries for Fiscal Year 2019 and 2020. Available at [federalregister.gov](https://www.federalregister.gov).

able (Dixit, Grossman, & Helpman, 1997; Voorn, van Genugten, & van Thiel, 2019). In the policy domains covered by aid conditionality, this can leave domestic voters with little leverage over policy even when electoral institutions remain intact. IMF conditionality provides a useful precedent, as loan conditions have insulated fiscal policy from electoral pressure in functioning democracies and weakened the link between voter preferences and public spending (Nooruddin & Simmons, 2006; Vreeland, 2003).

The Political Consequences of Crop Eradication

US-sponsored counternarcotics aid to source countries conditions assistance on the application of coercive force, regardless of domestic preferences. The motivating idea is that reducing the supply of illegal drugs abroad should reduce consumption in the United States. Yet eradication has proved largely ineffective at reducing cultivation in a sustained fashion (Farrell, 1998; Mejía et al., 2015; Moreno Sanchez et al., 2003). Its persistence despite these limited effects, along with its coercive implementation, has led researchers to study its unintended political consequences. That work shows potential for electoral backlash and violent resistance in response to eradication. In Colombia, aerial coca eradication reduced support for pro-eradication presidential candidates (Gélvez, 2024). Eradication has also increased guerrilla and other non-state armed violence as armed groups respond to threats to coca production and territorial control (Abadie et al., 2014; Campos-Contreras, Nieto-Matiz, & Schenoni, 2025).

Although recent work in Colombia documents electoral backlash after eradication, grievances over eradication need not be expressed only through vote choice. In Colombia, President Uribe made aerial spraying a cornerstone of his security policy, so voters in sprayed areas could punish it by voting against his candidates (Gélvez, 2024). In Bolivia, coca growers lacked an established partisan champion, yet decades of union organizing, coca's quasi-legal status tied to indigenous identity, and a political opening allowed them to build one through the Movimiento al Socialismo (Anria, 2013).

Crop Eradication in Mexico: Theoretical Expectations

I explore the political consequences of eradication for the communities that grow illegal crops in Mexico. To derive theoretical expectations, I draw on ethnographic research, journalistic accounts, and elite interviews. Mexico has eradicated illegal crops since at least 1969, when joint counternarcotics operations with the United States began (Cedillo, 2021).⁵ Counternarcotics operations quickly became central to the US-Mexico bilateral relationship, and have continued uninterrupted through the governments of three different parties since then.

Eradication policy is governed at the federal level (Delgado, 2021). Specifically, since 2007, the Mexican army has handled nearly all eradication duties, with the navy playing a marginal role.⁶ Unlike the aerial spraying campaigns that have characterized eradication in the Andean region (Campos-Contreras et al., 2025; Dion & Russler, 2008), the Mexican army overwhelmingly eradicates manually. Soldiers locate and secure the field, cut the plants, and incinerate them. In 2015 and 2018, 95% and 98% of all eradicated fields were destroyed manually.⁷

Ethnographic research reveals how, for the remote and marginalized communities where poppy and marijuana grow, the army is the most visible face of the federal government. Le Cour Grandmaison, Morris, and Smith (2019b) narrate how illegal crop fields were very visible and even close to the main street in town. In her ethnography of a crop-growing community in Guerrero, Álvarez Rodríguez (2021b) remarks:

“The most evident expression of the presence of the state is the eradication of poppy fields carried out by the Mexican army. Indeed, people often refer to the armed forces as ‘government’.”

Growers interpret the destruction of their fields as the government behaving punitively towards them, the weakest link in the drug-trafficking chain, rather than pursuing the criminals who gen-

⁵Two illegal crops grow in Mexico: poppy and marijuana. Unlike the Andean region, coca plants do not grow in Mexico. Coca requires acidic soil, high humidity, and particular mountain elevations found in the Andean region. Mexico’s predominantly alkaline soils and different topography make large-scale cultivation difficult, though isolated experimental plantings have been occasionally reported.

⁶Between 2013 and 2020, the navy was responsible for 2% of all destroyed poppy or marijuana hectares.

⁷Source: Freedom of information request folio 0000700198921.

erate violence (Álvarez Rodríguez, 2021b; Le Cour Grandmaison, 2021). As Álvarez Rodríguez (2021b) puts it:

“What local people find unjust is that the force of the law is applied, always, on the growers, never on those who make their living by extorting them.”

Eradication persists although it does not significantly affect drug-trafficking organizations’ (DTOs) profits. Growers, by and large, own their crops and bear the economic risk of cultivation. They sell the raw material to local intermediaries known as *coyotes*, who purchase the opium gum or marijuana in situ and transport it outside the growing region (Alvarez et al., 2022). Production is artisanal, irregular, and largely limited to small plots. While DTOs may exercise monopolistic control over certain growing regions, determine which *coyotes* can operate, and extract rents from the trade, they do not own the crops themselves and do not suffer direct economic losses from eradication, the step with the least value added in the drug-trafficking chain. Further, the economic independence of DTOs from illegal crop cultivation has intensified as synthetic drugs like fentanyl have gained popularity (Drug Enforcement Administration, 2021).

If institutional trust is the belief that a representative government agent will tend to act in one’s interest (Bhattacharya et al., 1998; Hardin, 2002), eradication teaches residents of crop-growing communities that government agents are not trustworthy. Because eradication is one of the few sustained ways in which these communities encounter the federal state, residents have little opportunity to revise that belief through more favorable interactions with government. As one farmer summarized, “They come, they destroy, and they leave.”⁸ A poppy farmer in Guerrero’s Sierra captures the structural trap that keeps growers tied to the illegal economy despite the government’s persecution: “If you plant, they [the government] persecute you; if you plant, they [the buyers] rip you off. That is always how it goes.” Asked why he keeps planting: “Because if you do not plant, you starve to death. That is the law.”⁹

H1: Eradication erodes trust in the federal security institutions responsible for coun-

⁸“Zozobra en la sierra de Guerrero por quema de plantíos de amapola,” *La Jornada*, April 14, 2018.

⁹Jan Martínez Ahrens, “La ley del opio en las montañas de Guerrero,” *El País*, June 19, 2016.

ternarcotics enforcement.

Crop-growing communities have no electoral recourse to attempt to influence eradication as policy. Eradication has continued under governments of three different parties and has never appeared on the electoral menu as a federal policy open to reform. Indeed, none of the platforms that parties and coalitions registered for the 2015 and 2018 federal elections propose ending eradication or offer an alternative to source-country operations (Appendix Section A3.4). Whatever party heads it, the federal government benefits from sustained eradication, which facilitates US security assistance, and the votes of small, poor, remote communities weigh little by comparison.

Top-level Mexican politicians understand this multiple-agent political calculus. I conducted four elite interviews with high-ranking Mexican politicians in May 2025 to ascertain the political logic of eradication from the source country's perspective.¹⁰ A former federal deputy explained: "They [the federal government] go after the poorest people. Neither heroin nor marijuana is a [financial] priority for organized crime anymore. It [eradication] is done to maintain good relations [with the US]." A former federal Senator described the logic as one of political inertia: "It's part of the script: we have to pay tribute to the flag, we have to play the bugle, we have to follow the regulations, well, we have to go burn crop fields." An ex-presidential Chief of Staff phrased it bluntly: "During the certification era, the US prevailed [over crop-growing communities]. Not meeting their [the US's] expectations could lead to 'decertification,' which was a major geopolitical blow. The local community hardly had a voice in these foreign policy decisions."

I expect eroded trust, in a context where viable electoral channels are lacking, to depress turnout. Political participation requires both motivation and viable channels for influence (Franklin, 2004; Verba, Nie, & Kim, 1978). Crop-growing communities have the motivation: they are aggrieved and distrust the federal government. But they lack the channel. No political force proposes reforming eradication policy. An inhabitant of a crop-growing community illustrates the resulting skepticism: "Who is going to help? The government? The government never helps" (Giménez Delgado, 2022, p. 225). Ethnographic accounts from Guerrero and Nayarit describe authorities dis-

¹⁰See Appendix Section A3 for details.

missing residents' demands because their livelihood is illegal (Appendix Section A3.5).

H2: Eradication depresses turnout in federal deputy elections.

Federal deputy elections offer a particularly clean test of this expectation, as they are held every three years and candidates are largely unknown to voters. Turnout in these elections reflects engagement with the federal government rather than the personalistic dynamics that shape presidential races.

Data

I draw on official data from the National Electoral Authority (INE) and the National Institute of Geography and Statistics (INEGI), as well as data I obtained from the Mexican army. Municipal-level data on illegal crop eradication operations come from official statistics published by the Mexican army. Additionally, using a freedom of information request, I obtained a list of all satellite-detected illegal crop fields identified by the army between February 2013 and June 2021, which I use to measure eradication at the electoral precinct level. Last, I use several waves of a national survey to measure changes in institutional trust. I explain each data source in more detail in the following subsections.

Outcomes of Interest. To measure trust in government institutions, I use institutional trust responses from seven waves (2013–2019) of the yearly National Survey of Crime Victimization and Public Safety (ENVIPE) (Instituto Nacional de Estadística y Geografía, 2019), which asks respondents to rate their trust in several law enforcement institutions. Appendix Section A7.1 reports the question wording and the response scale.

For turnout, I collected data on the four federal deputy elections held after the military took over eradication duties. I focus on federal deputy elections for both substantive and practical reasons. Substantively, unlike presidential elections, which are often shaped by personalistic dynamics, deputy elections offer repeated, comparable observations of political engagement with the federal government. Practically, deputy elections are held every three years, unlike other federal elections, which run on a six-year cycle, allowing me to include more electoral events in the analysis.

I rely on turnout data at the municipality and the electoral precinct levels. Electoral precincts are the basic geographic unit of Mexican elections. Each precinct has at least 100 voters, at most 3,000, and an average of about 1,200 registered voters (Challú, Seira, & Simpser, 2020). In rural communities, a single precinct can often cover the entire settlement, making that level of analysis well suited to examining the electoral consequences of highly localized eradication operations. Last, I exclude municipalities that select their authorities via indigenous self-governance (*usos y costumbres*) because their electoral processes and political structures differ substantially from the standard party-based system (Magaloni, Gosztonyi, & Thompson, 2022). Given the location of illegal fields, this culling excludes only 24 precincts from the sample.

Crop eradication. For information on the share and location of destroyed crops, I rely on two data sources based on official Mexican army information. The first consists of the type, number, and size of all illegal fields manually destroyed by the army, broken down by year, month, and municipality. The Mexican NGO México Unido Contra la Delincuencia collected, cleaned, and published these data (México Unido Contra la Delincuencia, 2021). The smallest geographic unit for which the Mexican army reports crop eradication operations is the municipality, but municipalities can be large. In contrast, illegal crop-growing communities are often small and rural. To overcome these data limitations, I used a freedom of information request to obtain a novel dataset containing the latitude and longitude of all poppy and marijuana fields detected by the army using satellite imagery between 2013 and June 2021, the two illegal crops grown in Mexico. In addition to the coordinates and detection date, these data report the surface area of each field and whether the army validated it as a true positive or a false positive.

Figure 1 shows the date and number of illegal crop fields detected via satellite per crop type. The Mexican army detected and destroyed poppy and marijuana fields during the entire period, but, as the figure shows, starting in 2015, poppy fields made up the majority of detected and destroyed fields. Detection is also seasonal, peaking in the dry months, when crops mature (Appendix Section A5.2). Since the data includes latitude and longitude, I can match each satellite image to an electoral precinct and count the number of satellite-detected fields in each precinct each month.

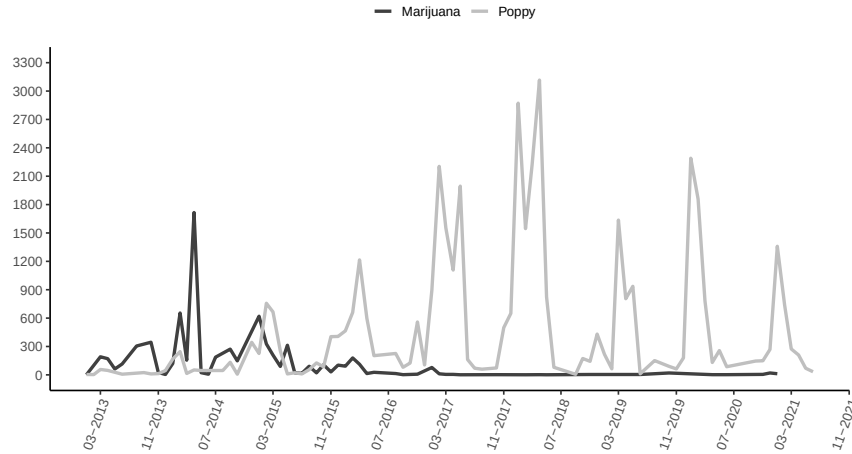


Figure 1: Monthly count of illegal fields detected by satellite, by crop type, as reported by the Mexican army, February 2013 to June 2021. The count excludes fields the army classified as false positives.

The army does not report whether or not it later eradicated the fields it detected. Therefore, to identify eradicated fields and date their destruction, I make use of the fact that the army incinerates most of the fields it destroys. I compare the geographic data on field detection with historical satellite data on fires¹¹, provided by the Fire Information for Resource Management System (FIRMS) (Giglio, Schroeder, Hall, & Justice, 2018). I classify fields as “eradicated” or “not eradicated” with the following algorithm:

1. Construct a 2km buffer around the coordinates of the illegal field, which accounts for the resolution of the fire data and for the distance between field coordinates and the exact burn location.
2. Keep all fires with a MODIS confidence score above 50 recorded within the buffer in the four months after the illegal field was detected, roughly the length of one crop cycle (Le Cour Grandmaison et al., 2019b).
3. If any fires were recorded within the buffer in that window, mark that field as eradicated.
4. Assign the eradication date as the date of the fire or, if multiple fires meet the criteria, as the

¹¹Following Hassan and O’Mealia (2018) I use the Moderate Resolution Imaging Spectroradiometer (MODIS) data.

day with the most fire detections (See Appendix Section A5.1 for details).

Out of the 53,509 illegal fields, 17,618 were detected in 2015 or 2018, the two federal election years with overlapping satellite imagery collection. The algorithm predicts that the army destroyed 15.8% of those fields within four months of detection: 2,683 within three months of the election and 104 earlier. It predicts eradication in seven states, 61 municipalities, and 321 electoral precincts. These 61 municipalities are concentrated in the two areas of most intensive illegal crop harvesting: the state of Guerrero in southwest Mexico and the so-called “Golden Triangle,” formed by the states of Sinaloa, Durango, and Chihuahua in the northwest. In the next section, I discuss this measure’s validity in depth and present several placebo tests to corroborate that it indeed captures eradication by incineration.

Constructing a measure of illegal field eradication using automated satellite imagery rather than ground patrols ensures that the treatment is orthogonal to bureaucratic capacity and criminal activity. However, the army also uses additional data sources to detect illegal crop fields, such as ground patrols and intelligence from other institutions. Consequently, the universe of municipalities where the army reports eradicating illegal crop fields is larger than the universe of municipalities where it detected illegal fields via satellite. Figure 2 shows the municipalities where the army reports eradicating illegal crops manually, as well as municipalities where it detected illegal fields via satellite in 2015 or 2018. Table A3 reports basic summary statistics. While the army reports at least one eradication operation in 433 municipalities, 93% of all hectares eradicated in 2015 or 2018 were destroyed in municipalities with satellite-detected illegal fields, suggesting a large overlap between the two measures of eradication.

Empirical Strategy

The following section presents the empirical strategy for measuring the effect of eradication on institutional trust. Additionally, it explains two empirical strategies for measuring the effect of eradication on turnout.

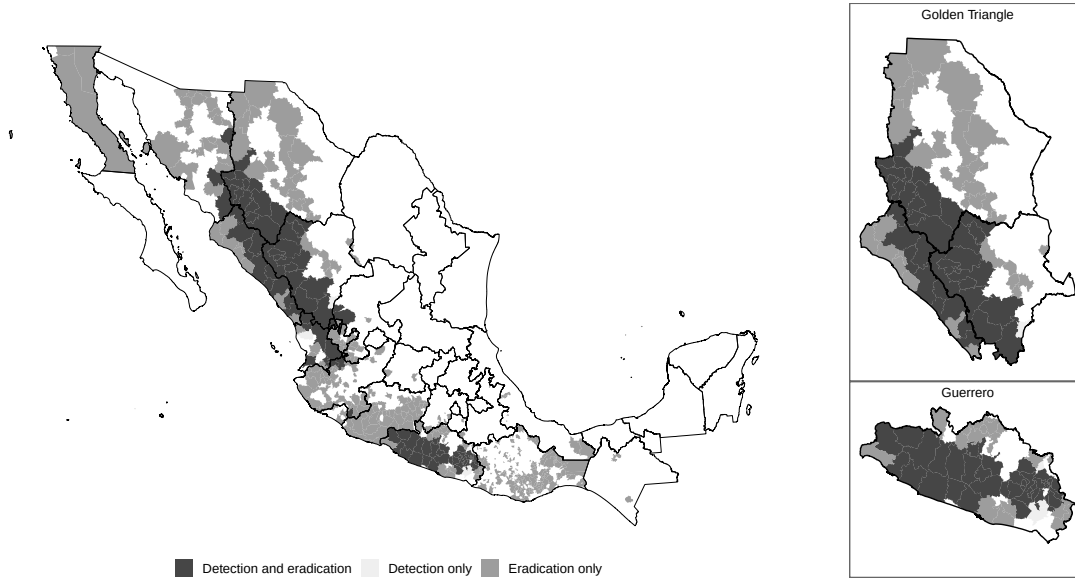


Figure 2: Municipalities where the Mexican army reports conducting eradication operations in either 2015 or 2018, as well as municipalities with at least one positive satellite detection of illegal crop fields. Insets zoom into the two principal crop-producing regions: the Golden Triangle (Sinaloa, Durango, Chihuahua) and Guerrero.

Trust. I test the effects of illegal crop eradication on institutional trust using responses from seven waves (2013–2019) of the ENVIPE, a yearly nationally representative survey. The analytical leverage in this design stems from the temporal variation in survey collection timing relative to eradication operations within the same calendar year for a given municipality. I leverage the timing of the survey to compare self-reported attitudes toward institutions in municipalities where the government eradicated illegal fields before survey collection began with those of respondents living in municipalities where the government eradicated fields *after* the survey was collected. All seven waves of the ENVIPE were collected by the National Institute of Statistics (INEGI) between March and April, with some municipalities surveyed in the first month and others in the second, depending on INEGI logistics.

I pooled the seven survey waves and kept respondents living in a municipality where the army reported eradicating at least one illegal field during the survey year. The unit of analysis is the respondent, and the level of treatment assignment is the municipality-year. Because illegal crops grow in remote rural areas, the main analysis focuses on rural respondents, who live where the fields are and where eradication takes place. ENVIPE also surveys residents of urban settlements

in the same municipalities. Although I assign them the same treatment status, they are unlikely to grow illegal crops or to witness eradication, so I use them as a placebo group. If the drop in trust reflected something affecting the whole municipality in years of early eradication, urban respondents should show it too. ENVIPE fieldwork takes place in March and April, and the survey does not record the interview date. For municipalities eradicated in March or April but not in January or February, the survey and eradication order is therefore unknown. I exclude them and keep only municipalities eradicated clearly before the survey (January or February) or clearly after (May onward). Appendix Table A16 keeps the excluded municipalities as controls instead. Because some of their respondents were surveyed after eradication, the estimates attenuate, as expected, and remain negative. After pooling, I have data from 20,382 respondents in rural communities across 283 municipalities observed over seven survey waves, 51 of which switch treatment status during the analysis period. I fit a series of models with the following specification:

$$Y_{it[m]} = \gamma \text{EradicationBefore}_{tm} + \beta \mathbf{X}_{it} + \mu_t + \theta_m + \varepsilon_{it[m]} \quad (1)$$

Where $Y_{it[m]}$ is respondent i 's self-reported attitude towards a state institution in year t for a respondent living in municipality m . $\text{EradicationBefore}_{tm}$ is a dummy that takes the value of 1 if municipality m was eradicated in January or February of year t , before ENVIPE fieldwork begins, and zero if eradication occurred only after the survey was collected. μ_t are year fixed-effects, θ_m are municipality fixed-effects, and $\mathbf{X}_{it}$ are respondent-level sociodemographic characteristics. Robust errors are clustered at the municipality level.

The estimand is the average treatment effect on the treated (ATT), the change in institutional trust among rural respondents in municipalities eradicated before the survey relative to what their trust would have been without eradication. Formally, $\hat{\gamma}$ in equation (1) estimates $E[Y_i(1) - Y_i(0) \mid D_m = 1, \theta_m, \mu_t]$, where the treatment $D_m = 1$ indicates that municipality m was eradicated before survey collection. The identifying assumption is that, absent treatment, municipalities eradicated before survey collection would exhibit similar institutional trust as municipalities eradicated after,

conditional on municipality and year fixed effects. Four features of the design and the data support this assumption. INEGI sets fieldwork dates nationally in March and April each year, and treatment is defined outside those months. The army's eradication calendar follows the crop cycle rather than the survey calendar (Appendix Figure A10). Municipality fixed effects, moreover, absorb any fixed feature of a municipality that makes it easier for the army or survey teams to reach it, so identification comes from the 51 municipalities that are eradicated before the survey in some years and after it in others. Accessibility, finally, is also unrelated to which fields the army eradicates. Within military zone and year, neither distance to army headquarters nor road access predicts which detected fields are eradicated (Appendix Table A13).

A second assumption for identification is that sample composition does not change differently between the treatment and control groups. In this design, individuals (surveyed once) are nested in municipalities. If eradication alters which types of individuals respond to the survey, estimates could be biased. Appendix Section A7.4 shows that eradication timing does not predict differences in respondent demographics, familiarity with institutions, or, with one exception, non-response patterns.

Lastly, while ENVIPE is nationally representative at the urban-rural level, it is not designed to be representative at the municipal level. This limits the generalizability of effect magnitudes to the national population but does not threaten identification, which requires only comparability between early- and late-eradicated municipalities within the sample.

Crop eradication: Electoral precinct. Two features of Mexico's eradication program structure the identification strategy: the army's geographic organization and its finite operational capacity. Together, they generate variation in which satellite-detected precincts are eradicated before a given election that is plausibly exogenous conditional on zone, year, and cumulative targeting history.

The army organizes operations around military zones, each commanded by an officer responsible for all operations within the zone, including eradication (SEDENA, 2012). Using freedom of information requests, I assigned each municipality, and by extension each electoral precinct, to its

military zone.¹² Zone fixed effects, therefore, absorb the zone-level factors that govern how eradication is allocated across detected precincts: common resource constraints, targeting priorities, and operational infrastructure.

The second design pillar is finite capacity. The army detects far more illegal crop fields than it can destroy in any campaign period: SEDENA's report on counternarcotics operations (SDN-MD-11) lists geography, weather, and logistical capacity as the factors governing which detected fields are scheduled for eradication (SEDENA, 2012).¹³ Importantly, this capacity constraint does not mean the army permanently spares any community: Appendix Table A8 shows that eradication is nearly inevitable for persistently detected precincts over time. The identifying variation is therefore in the timing of eradication relative to elections, not in selection into the program.

Beyond zone and year, I also condition on each precinct's prior history of eradication. Two precincts in the same zone with detected crops in the same year can still be poor counterfactuals if they differ sharply in how often cultivation has been detected and eradicated in the past. Repeated eradication may reflect both persistent cultivation and accumulated army experience operating in a precinct, either of which could affect current targeting and turnout. I summarize this history with the prior eradication rate, defined as the share of previous years with detected fields in which a precinct was also eradicated. I then divide precincts into a high-rate stratum, above 50%, and a low-rate stratum, at or below 50%.¹⁴ The resulting fixed effects include military zone, election year, and prior-eradication-rate bin.

The sample consists of 1,037 precinct-year observations from the 2015 and 2018 federal deputy elections. All precincts in the sample had at least one satellite-detected illegal crop field during the relevant election period. Treatment is the eradication of at least one detected field before the election, measured either as a binary indicator or as the log-transformed number of destroyed

¹²Figure A1 in the Appendix shows the result. Military regions encompass several zones; a region can span two to five states, while a single zone can straddle municipalities in different states. A single state can contain as many as five military zones, as in Chiapas.

¹³This account was corroborated in an interview with a high-ranking armed forces officer responsible for overseeing eradication operations, conducted by the author.

¹⁴Appendix Figure A5 shows that the estimates are negative at every cutoff from 10% to 90% and statistically distinguishable from zero from 30% onward. Appendix Table A9 shows that they remain negative and similar in size with three strata, with rate as a continuous control, and with no adjustment for rate.

fields or eradicated area (in thousands of square meters). I measure exposure with counts rather than with the share of fields eradicated for two reasons. First, the argument is about the experience of destruction, which grows with the number of destroyed fields. Second, the denominator of such a share is not precisely observed. At the precinct level, the army also detects fields through ground patrols and intelligence it does not report, so satellite detections are only a subset of cultivated fields. At the municipal level, the army reports the fields it destroyed but not the fields it detected. I therefore include the number of satellite-detected fields as a balancing covariate rather than as a denominator, so that treated and control precincts are compared at similar levels of detected cultivation.

In the preferred specification, I refine the comparison within cells on three pre-election characteristics, namely satellite-detected fields, schooling, and employment share, because cultivation intensity and socioeconomic profile are the most plausible sources of remaining differences in targeting and turnout within cells. To reduce model dependence and target the average treatment effect on the treated, I pre-process the sample using entropy balancing (Hainmueller, 2012), which reweights control precincts to exactly match the means of treated precincts on these three characteristics (Appendix Table A10). I fit the following weighted fixed-effects regression:

$$Y_{pt} = \gamma D_{pt} + \beta \mathbf{X}_p + \mu_{z(p) \times t \times h(p,t)} + \varepsilon_{pt} \quad (2)$$

where Y_{pt} is the turnout rate of electoral precinct p during election year t . D_{pt} is the treatment: either a dummy for any pre-election predicted eradication or the $(\log + 1)$ number of fields or area, in thousands of square meters, predicted eradicated. $\mathbf{X}_p$ are controls (pre-election satellite-detected fields, schooling, and employment share), included as linear covariates in one specification and replaced by entropy balancing weights on the same covariates in the preferred specification. $\mu_{z(p) \times t \times h(p,t)}$ are zone $\times$ year $\times$ prior-eradication-rate-bin fixed effects, where $h(p, t)$ indicates whether precinct p 's prior eradication rate is above or below 50%. All specifications also include a fixed effect for whether the precinct's municipality held a mayoral election the same day. Robust standard errors are clustered at the electoral precinct level.

The estimand is the average treatment effect on the treated (ATT) among precincts with satellite-detected illegal crop fields:

$$\tau_{ATT} = E[Y_p(1) - Y_p(0) \mid D_p = 1, \mathbf{X}_p, \mu_{z(p) \times t \times h(p,t)}], \quad (3)$$

the effect of election-year eradication on turnout for precincts where eradication occurred, conditional on being in the same zone-year, having similar prior targeting histories, and conditional on the observed covariates. The population of inference is precincts already participating in the illegal crop economy. The identifying assumption is conditional ignorability within zone-year-prior-eradication-rate cells and controls:

$$\{Y_p(1), Y_p(0)\} \perp\!\!\!\perp D_p \mid \mathbf{X}_p, \mu_{z(p) \times t \times h(p,t)}. \quad (4)$$

Two pieces of evidence support the plausibility of conditional ignorability within cells. The geographic selection test in Table A13 shows that distance to army headquarters does not predict eradication within zone-year cells or within the full zone-year-prior-eradication-rate-bin cells. The full set of geographic covariates, distance, altitude, road access, and land cover, explains less than 1% of the within-cell variation in which fields are eradicated (within-cell $R^2 = 0.005$). Table A10 in the Appendix shows that entropy balancing equalizes the means of the three balancing covariates between treated and control precincts. I assess additional threats to identification in the Alternative Explanations section.

Crop eradication: Municipality. My second empirical strategy uses official municipal-level eradication data, published monthly by the Mexican army. This design relies on different assumptions than the precinct-level analysis: whereas the precinct-level design relies on conditional exogeneity within zone-year-prior-eradication-rate cells, the municipal design exploits within-municipality variation over time in a four-election panel (2009, 2012, 2015, and 2018). My sample includes all municipalities where the army eradicated fields in at least one election year. For comparability with the precinct-level results, I exclude municipalities that select their authorities through Indigenous

self-governance from the sample. The final sample includes 1,664 municipality-year observations from 597 municipalities, covering 96% of the hectares destroyed by the army. Of these, 1,253 municipality-year observations had eradication either before or after the election in a given year; this is the estimation sample for the TWFE specification.¹⁵

The variation I leverage for identification comes from the timing of field eradication. I compare municipal turnout in election years when the army manually eradicated fields before the election with turnout in the same municipality in other election years, when eradication happened only after the election. The central identifying assumption is that, absent treatment, municipalities eradicated before the election would have experienced the same trends in electoral turnout as those eradicated after the election. I estimate the following two-way fixed-effects model:

$$Y_{mt} = \gamma \text{EradicationBefore}_{mt} + \mu_t + \theta_m + \varepsilon_{mt} \quad (5)$$

where Y_{mt} is the turnout rate in municipality m during election year t and $\text{EradicationBefore}_{mt}$ is a dummy variable that takes the value of 1 if the army eradicated illegal fields manually in year t and municipality m during the months before the federal election and 0 if it eradicated fields only after the elections, or the (log+1) count of fields or hectares eradicated manually in the same period. μ_t are year fixed-effects, and θ_m are municipality fixed-effects. Robust standard errors are clustered at the municipality. The municipality fixed effects θ_m account for all time-invariant municipal characteristics, including differences in average turnout and in the intensity of eradication. The identifying variation therefore comes from deviations of each municipality's turnout and eradication from their municipal averages over the four elections, net of the year effects.

The estimand is the average treatment effect on the treated (ATT) among municipalities where the army eradicated in a given year. Formally, $\hat{\gamma}$ in equation (5) estimates $E[Y_m(1) - Y_m(0) \mid D_{mt} = 1, \theta_m, \mu_t]$, the effect of pre-election eradication on turnout for municipalities that experi-

¹⁵The municipal sample is larger than the precinct-level sample (1,037 observations) for two reasons. First, the municipal analysis uses official army eradication reports covering all eradication operations across all four election cycles (2009–2018), while the precinct analysis is restricted to precincts with satellite-detected fields in the two election years (2015, 2018) with overlapping satellite imagery. Second, municipalities appear in multiple election cycles in the panel, while each precinct-year is a single observation.

enced it, relative to what their turnout would have been had eradication occurred after the election.

The identifying assumption is parallel trends. Absent pre-election eradication, treated municipalities would have followed the same turnout trajectory as municipalities eradicated after the election. Because eradication is a recurring treatment that varies within municipalities across election cycles rather than a one-time shock, standard pre-trends tests do not apply. Instead, I test the timing structure directly by estimating variants of equation (5) that replace current eradication with prior-cycle eradication, that is, eradication in the municipality before the previous federal election, or with post-election eradication. If confounding rather than eradication drives the result, these placebo treatments should also predict turnout. I report the results in columns 2–4 of Table 2.

Results

Trust. First, I examine how eradication affects people’s self-reported levels of trust in law enforcement and justice institutions, using data from the ENVIPE survey. The results for rural respondents, shown in dark gray in Figure 3, indicate that eradication in rural areas reduced people’s trust in federal security institutions. Reported trust in the army is 0.08 standard deviations lower when respondents lived in a municipality eradicated before survey collection. Trust in the navy (-0.12 SD) and federal police (-0.13 SD) is also significantly lower. Like the army, both are part of the federal government’s coercive apparatus. Residents likely update their beliefs about that apparatus as a whole rather than about the army alone. The navy, moreover, eradicates a small share of fields itself, which likely reinforces this association. By contrast, trust in state police, prosecutors, and judges, which are either not federal or not policing institutions, does not change. The decline is thus confined to the federal coercive apparatus, as the theory predicts if eradication informs communities about the priorities of the federal government. Residents encounter that government through its armed forces, which, ethnographic accounts report, residents call simply “government” (Álvarez Rodríguez, 2021b).

Next, I use respondents from urban settlements in the same municipalities as a placebo. Eradication occurs in rural areas, so urban residents in the same municipalities are a natural comparison

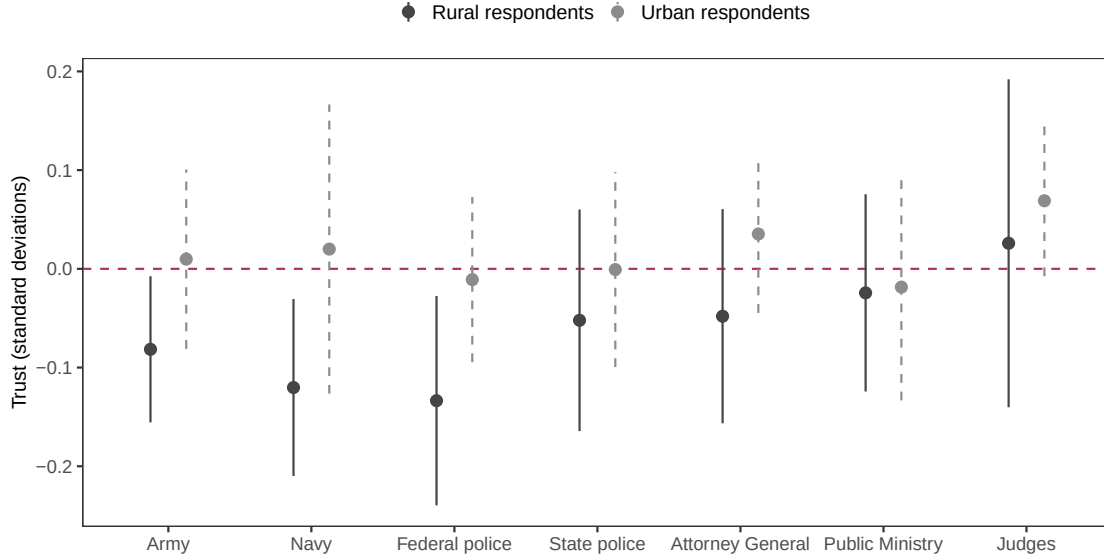


Figure 3: Difference in self-reported trust between respondents in municipalities eradicated before and after survey collection, with 95% confidence intervals. Dark gray: rural respondents. Light gray: urban respondents in the same municipalities, used as a placebo. All specifications include municipality and year fixed effects and respondent controls (age, sex, and education). Standard errors are clustered by municipality.

group that eradication does not directly affect. If the decline in trust comes from eradication, their trust should not change. I report the results in light gray in Figure 3. Reassuringly, the estimates for trust in the army and other federal security agencies are close to zero among urban respondents, despite the sample being more than twice as large. The contrast between rural and urban patterns supports the interpretation that eradication, rather than a broader municipal trend, drives the observed decline in trust.

While survey evidence indicates that people exposed to eradication then trust the armed forces and the federal police less, one possible threat to identification is that people in communities eradicated earlier in the year are generally less trusting and thus participate less in elections. I test this possibility by comparing their responses to self-reported trust in family and neighbors, and report the results in Figure A11. I find no significant difference in these measures, and the point estimates are very close to zero.

Crop eradication: Electoral precinct. Table 1 presents the precinct-level results from specification (2), contrasting precincts where the army detected but did not eradicate illegal fields against

precincts where it both detected and eradicated fields, within the same zone-year-prior-eradication-rate cell. The table reports three specifications in order of increasing covariate adjustment: no controls (Row 1), three linear controls for pre-election satellite-detected fields, schooling, and employment share (Row 2), and entropy balancing on the same three covariates (Row 3, preferred). All three rows include zone $\times$ year $\times$ prior-eradication-rate-bin fixed effects.

Without covariate adjustment, all three treatment measures are negative and statistically significant. Any eradication reduces turnout by 2.1 percentage points on average. One-unit increases in log eradicated area and log destroyed fields reduce turnout by 1.06 and 1.32 points, respectively. Adding three linear controls (Row 2) attenuates the estimates slightly. All three remain negative and significant at the 10% level.

In the preferred, entropy-balanced specification, all three treatment measures are negative and statistically significant at the 5% level. Any eradication reduces turnout by 2.4 percentage points. One-unit increases in log eradicated area and log destroyed fields reduce turnout by 1.13 and 1.37 points, respectively. To put these magnitudes in context, the median eradicated area among treated precincts is about 6,000 square meters, or 0.6 hectares. Eradicating that area reduces turnout by $\ln(6 + 1) \times -1.13 \approx -2.2$ points, or 13% of a standard deviation. At the median number of destroyed fields among treated precincts (3), the estimate implies $\ln(3 + 1) \times -1.37 \approx -1.9$ points, or 12% of a standard deviation.¹⁶ Exposure to eradication is communal. In the small towns where illegal crops grow, the army's arrival is likely visible to the entire community. Indeed, ethnographic work finds that at least 75% of households in a crop-growing town in Nayarit, and more than 95% of men in one in Guerrero, earn income from illegal crops (Le Cour Grandmaison et al., 2019b). Few residents are likely to welcome the army's entry into their town (Álvarez Rodríguez, 2021b). The precinct estimates therefore likely describe the response of an average resident of an exposed town, rather than a large response concentrated among the owners of burned fields.

A complementary check asks whether eradication redirects rather than suppresses participation. If communities blame the PRI, the incumbent party in both 2015 and 2018, and vote strategically

¹⁶Table A6 in the Appendix presents results using untransformed counts. The findings remain consistent.

	Turnout		
	Dummy (1)	Eradicated area (log) (2)	Fields (log) (3)
<i>Row 1: No controls</i>	−2.102* (0.964) [<i>p</i> = 0.030]	−1.056** (0.404) [<i>p</i> = 0.009]	−1.318** (0.510) [<i>p</i> = 0.010]
<i>Row 2: + Controls</i>	−1.676+ (0.991) [<i>p</i> = 0.091]	−0.922+ (0.472) [<i>p</i> = 0.051]	−1.102+ (0.599) [<i>p</i> = 0.066]
<i>Row 3: Entropy balanced</i>	−2.425* (1.214) [<i>p</i> = 0.046]	−1.129* (0.476) [<i>p</i> = 0.018]	−1.368* (0.601) [<i>p</i> = 0.023]
FE: Zone × Year × Prior-erad-rate bin	Yes	Yes	Yes
Concurrent election control	Yes	Yes	Yes
Num.Obs.	1037	1037	1037

+ *p* < 0.1, * *p* < 0.05, ** *p* < 0.01. Exact *p*-values in brackets.

Table 1: Illegal crop eradication and turnout in federal elections for deputies: precinct-level results. The dependent variable is turnout as a share of registered voters. Eradicated area is in thousands of square meters. Row 1 includes only the fixed effects. Row 2 adds linear controls for pre-election detected fields, schooling, and employment share. Row 3 (preferred) uses entropy balancing on the same covariates. Standard errors are clustered by precinct.

against it, its vote share would shift without a decline in aggregate turnout. Appendix Table A5 reports the effect of eradication on PRI vote share. The EB-weighted estimates are small, statistically imprecise, and inconsistent in sign across the three treatment measures. There is no evidence that eradication redirects votes toward or away from the incumbent party, supporting the interpretation that communities withdraw from electoral participation rather than channeling grievances through vote choice.

Measurement concerns

One concern when interpreting the results in Table 1 is that the effects capture something unrelated to eradication, since treatment is predicted rather than observed. I conduct several ancillary analyses to validate the quality of the measure.

First, I use the 8.1% of the satellite detection data observations that the army labeled as false positives. I classify these “false” fields as eradicated using the same algorithm described in the previous section and estimate the effect of their “destruction” on turnout. One way to conceptualize the effect of “false field eradication” on turnout is as the effect of wildfires or controlled burns in places *without* illegal fields. Table A7 reports the results of this placebo test. Suppose predicted eradication in true illegal fields systematically captures false positives. In that case, the effects reported in Table 1 should be similar in direction and magnitude to the estimates in columns 1–2 of Table A7. However, neither the binary indicator nor the log count of destroyed false-positive fields approaches conventional levels of statistical significance, and the two point estimates go in opposite directions. Results lend credibility to the fire-based algorithm.

Second, I contrast the algorithm’s results, aggregated at the municipality level, with the official municipal-level data published by the army. I then check municipalities where the algorithm predicts eradication during months when the army reports no cases. Predicted destroyed fields in municipalities during months when no official eradication occurred accounted for only 7.6% and 13.0% of all predicted eradicated fields in 2015 and 2018. This low percentage of false positives does not account for incorrectly dated true positives: fields destroyed in these municipalities, but in the month before or after the one predicted by the algorithm.

Last, I benchmark the satellite measure against official geolocated army eradication data for 2019 and 2020. Comparing the fire-based predictions to army-reported destruction, 9.45% of the precincts the measure codes as control had army-reported destruction, and 22.8% of the precincts it codes as treated had none. Some eradicated precincts appear as controls because MODIS records a fire only if a 1km pixel is hot enough during one of its daily overpasses and the sky is clear (Giglio et al., 2018). Both figures may overstate misclassification, because the army eradicates fields detected by satellite, ground, and aerial surveillance, and both fires and army records are matched to satellite-detected fields by proximity. Both types of misclassification bias the estimated effect toward zero, so the reported estimates remain conservative. Appendix Figure A6 shows how the unadjusted coefficient distribution shifts as misclassification rates vary. The median simulated

coefficient remains negative even when half of the precincts are misclassified in either direction.

Finally, I assess whether the results depend on the two central measurement decisions: the 2km buffer or the four-month window. Appendix Figure A7 rebuilds the treatment, and the prior-eradication-rate strata with it, for every buffer from 1 to 4km and every window from 2 to 4 months, and re-estimates the preferred specification. I find that all 36 estimates are negative. The area and field measures are significant at the 5% level in every combination, and the binary indicator in half of them, suggesting measurement decisions of predicted eradication do not spuriously drive the results.

Crop eradication: Municipality. Next, I present the results of specification (5). All municipal-level analyses use official monthly data on crop eradication reported by the army, along with a four-election panel (2009–2018). This design relies on within-municipality variation over time rather than within-zone-year cross-sectional variation, and it uses administrative eradication records rather than the satellite-based measure. If both designs converge, the result is unlikely to be an artifact of either identification strategy alone.

Table 2 reports the effects of current pre-election eradication on turnout in column 1, with three treatment measures as rows: log hectares, log fields, and any eradication. A one-unit increase in log hectares decreases turnout by 0.98 percentage points; the log fields estimate implies a 0.49 percentage-point reduction. The continuous measures are estimated more precisely than the binary indicator, as expected from the added variation. To contextualize, going from no eradication to the median among eradicated municipality-years (2.6 hectares, or 18 fields) reduces turnout by approximately 1.3 percentage points using the hectares measure ($\ln(2.6 + 1) \times 0.98$), or 1.5 percentage points using the fields measure ($\ln(18 + 1) \times 0.49$).

Year- and municipal-fixed effects control for time-invariant unit-specific confounders and year-specific shocks common to all municipalities. The timing tests in columns 2–4 provide additional evidence against confounding: if an unobserved time-varying confounder drove the results, lagged eradication should also predict turnout, which it does not.¹⁷ Adding turnout in the previous fed-

¹⁷In columns 2 and 4, municipality-years from 2009, the first period in the panel, and municipalities not eradicated

	Current (1)	Lagged (2)	Post-election (3)	Current + Lagged (4)
<i>Hectares (log)</i>				
Eradication	−0.981** (0.344) [<i>p</i> = 0.004]	0.179 (0.389) [<i>p</i> = 0.646]	−0.056 (0.348) [<i>p</i> = 0.873]	−0.815+ (0.458) [<i>p</i> = 0.076]
Lagged				−0.024 (0.403) [<i>p</i> = 0.952]
<i>Fields (log)</i>				
Eradication	−0.494* (0.233) [<i>p</i> = 0.034]	0.158 (0.305) [<i>p</i> = 0.605]	0.072 (0.231) [<i>p</i> = 0.754]	−0.564+ (0.318) [<i>p</i> = 0.077]
Lagged				−0.005 (0.307) [<i>p</i> = 0.988]
<i>Any eradication (dummy)</i>				
Eradication	−1.763+ (0.927) [<i>p</i> = 0.058]			
FE: Municipality, Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>N</i>	1,253	657	1,253	657

+ *p* < 0.1, * *p* < 0.05, ** *p* < 0.01. Cluster-robust SEs at the municipality level.

Table 2: Illegal crop eradication and turnout: municipal-level TWFE. The dependent variable is turnout as a share of registered voters. “Current” is eradication before the election in the same year. Columns 2 and 3 are placebos. “Lagged” is eradication before the previous federal election, and “Post-election” is eradication after the election. Column 4 includes current and lagged eradication jointly.

eral election as a control leaves the column 1 estimates nearly unchanged (Appendix Table A2). The sharp contemporaneity of the effect is difficult to reconcile with the systematic selection of eradicated places that obeys baseline levels or differential trends in marginalization. Instead, this pattern is consistent with a causal effect that operates through the experience of eradication in the run-up to an election.

For the continuous treatment specifications to recover an average causal effect, treatment effects must be reasonably constant across dosages (Callaway, Goodman-Bacon, & Sant’Anna, 2024). I fit the same models with a flexible ten-knot cubic regression spline and plot the results in Figure A3. The effects are plausibly constant across dosages for log hectares but heterogeneous for log fields.

Alternative Explanations

Selection. The precinct- and municipal-level results both show that eradication reduces turnout. A central concern is that the results are mechanically driven by selection, whereby the army targets the most marginalized communities within zone-year-prior-eradication-rate-bin cells, and that these communities also participate least in politics. Four pieces of evidence are inconsistent with this possibility.

First, if the army targeted already-disengaged communities, turnout in eradicated precincts should have been lower than in comparison precincts even before eradication began. Eradication recurs, so the two groups differ in whether the army eradicated their fields before election day that year, not in whether the army targets them at all. To test this, I compare precincts eradicated before the election with comparison precincts on turnout in elections held before the satellite detection program started, which does not enter the entropy balancing. Turnout in 2012 and 2009 differs little and not significantly between the two groups, indicating that eradicated precincts were not more politically disengaged before the program (Appendix Table A10).

Second, the municipal-level timing tests in Table 2 provide a different cut at the same concern.

in the previous cycle have no lagged value and are excluded from these specifications.

If the selection story is correct, the communities the army targets should be persistently disadvantaged, not temporarily so. Persistent disadvantage would show up as a correlation between eradication in any period and lower turnout. Yet eradication before the previous election does not predict current turnout, and neither does eradication after the election. Only eradication before the current election predicts turnout. The effect is therefore tied to the timing of destruction, not to the characteristics of the places where destruction occurs.

Third, I assess whether soldiers systematically choose to eradicate more accessible fields. The army’s own *Protocolo Nacional de Actuación para la Destrucción de Plantíos Ilícitos* states that operational teams create action plans “taking into account the geography of the location, meteorological and demographic conditions” when planning eradication operations. Table A13 in the Appendix reports field-level linear probability models regressing an indicator for eradication on distance to military zone headquarters, with progressively more demanding fixed effects. Distance to headquarters does not predict eradication within zone $\times$ year cells ($p = 0.91$) or within the full zone $\times$ year $\times$ prior-eradication-rate-bin cells used for identification ($p = 0.70$). Geography as a whole explains less than 1% of the variation in which detected fields are eradicated within those cells.

Fourth, the treatment coefficients are similar across the three specifications in Table 1, which include no controls, linear controls, and entropy balancing on the same precinct characteristics. The main result is therefore not sensitive to how I adjust for these characteristics, and imbalance in them is unlikely to drive it.

Income. A reasonable concern is that eradication depresses turnout because people lose income and cannot vote, rather than through changes in citizens’ beliefs and electoral incentives. Research on income and voting in Latin America generally finds a null or weak association (Carreras & Castañeda-Angarita, 2014). Eradication is nonetheless a negative resource shock for crop-growing communities, where the illegal economy is central to local livelihoods.¹⁸ The income effect of eradication is unlikely to operate in the short run, however, because raw opium gum and marijuana

¹⁸For instance, Le Cour Grandmaison et al. (2019b) estimate that at least 75% of households in a crop-growing town in Nayarit and more than 95% of men in a crop-growing town in Guerrero profited directly from illegal harvesting.

are not immediately fungible: growers must wait for intermediaries to purchase the harvest, and the income loss materializes over subsequent months rather than at the moment of destruction.

To test, I first leverage the 2018 collapse of the price of poppy due to the increased demand for fentanyl. While poppy sold at record prices between 2014 and 2017, its price fell by around 50% in 2018 (Le Cour Grandmaison, Morris, & Smith, 2019a; Sáez, 2024). Thus, the lost income from an eradicated field in 2015 was significantly higher than that from one eradicated just three years later (Appendix Section A6.1). The estimated effect is close to zero in 2015, when poppy prices were high, and negative in 2018, after they fell, and I cannot reject that the two are equal. If lost income drove the result, the effect should be larger in 2015, when a destroyed field represented a greater economic loss. The evidence therefore suggests that the negative economic shock of eradication cannot explain the results, at least in isolation.

To probe the income channel further, I leverage precinct-level luminosity data (Magar, 2021), a measure often used as a proxy for economic activity (Henderson, Storeygard, & Weil, 2012). Results show no significant differences in luminosity between eradicated and non-eradicated precincts in the three years before or after treatment (Appendix Section A6.1). Like the price test, the luminosity results are inconsistent with lost income driving the decline in turnout, at least in the short run.

Compositional changes. I consider whether population changes could explain the observed effects. I first consider whether arrests for eradication could mechanically decrease turnout by reducing the population. Using a freedom of information request, I obtained data on the number of people sentenced for illegal crop farming each year. Although growing illegal crops is a felony, the data show that the penalty is not routinely enforced. Specifically, while the mean yearly number of sentences for illegal crop harvesting between 2007 and 2020 was only 59, the mean number of eradicated fields in the same period was 188,691, according to the Attorney General’s office.

Second, one could worry that eradication operations force people to leave their communities and find work elsewhere. Ethnographic work has documented migration away from crop-growing communities. However, the phenomenon is linked to changes in crop-harvesting profitability, not

government activity. In fact, historians have pointed to crop-harvesting profitability as a tool that has allowed communities to *resist* pressure to emigrate to cities (Le Cour Grandmaison et al., 2019a). Additionally, the control group should account for any changes in migratory pressures common to crop-growing communities.

However, given extant work on displacement and coca fumigation in Colombia (Dion & Rusler, 2008), this channel is essential to examine. To do so, I use data on voter address changes between electoral precincts. While this measure will miss individuals who do not keep their address up to date with the electoral authority, in Mexico more than 97% of eligible voters have a valid voting ID card (Finan, Seira, & Simpser, 2021). Few registered voters moved between eradicated and comparison precincts in either direction, providing no evidence that population displacement served as a mechanism (Appendix Section A6.2).

Violence. Lastly, I consider whether eradication operations might affect participation by altering criminal violence, possibly disrupting DTOs' revenue streams, fostering competition between criminal organizations, or incentivizing them to resort to extortion to compensate for financial losses. This mechanism is improbable because growers, rather than cartels, typically own the crops and absorb the economic costs (Álvarez Rodríguez, 2021a; Farfán-Mendez, 2021), and because cartels have diversified toward synthetic drugs like fentanyl (Drug Enforcement Administration, 2021), which eradication does not affect.

Measures of municipal cartel presence based on news reporting exist (Esberg, 2025), but no comparable measure of cartel violence does. I therefore use official homicide data, since homicides are the best-measured crime and the least susceptible to underreporting in low-trust contexts (World Health Organization, 2014). I use both overall homicides and firearm homicides, which are more sensitive to DTO violence (Vela Barba & Atuesta, 2022), at the municipal level, the smallest unit for which both homicides and turnout are consistently reported.

I replicate the specification from equation 5, adding lagged municipal homicide counts as controls. If violence were the primary channel through which eradication affects participation, controlling for violence should substantially attenuate the eradication coefficients. Moreover, if

eradication operates through violence to depress turnout, violence should be negatively associated with turnout. Table A15 in the Appendix shows instead that, across all specifications, eradication effects remain substantively unchanged when controlling for lagged municipal homicides, with coefficients nearly identical to those in Table 2. Both firearm homicides and total homicides show small but statistically significant *positive* associations with turnout, the opposite of what a violence-mediated mechanism predicts.

Discussion

The results show that illegal crop eradication in Mexico erodes trust in the federal security apparatus and depresses turnout in federal elections instead of engendering electoral backlash. When the army burns their fields, residents of crop-growing communities learn that the federal government, represented by its coercive bureaucracies, will not act in their interest. Consequently, trust in the army, the navy, and the federal police declines. However, instead of channeling their grievances by voting, residents are more likely to abstain in federal elections. US conditionality leaves no political force in Mexico able to credibly offer to suspend eradication, leaving no space for electoral backlash. Original elite interviews show that politicians understand the political calculus by which US interests prevail over those of crop-growing communities. Ethnographic work shows that the communities subjected to eradication understand it as well. In the words of one elderly grower, “the government treats us like third-class citizens” (Álvarez Rodríguez, 2021b).

The results in this paper capture the short-term consequences of contemporaneous eradication and likely understate the harm eradication does to crop-growing communities for two reasons. First, eradication is hard to observe, and the resulting measurement error attenuates the estimates toward zero. Second, and more importantly, the design estimates the effect of recent, pre-election eradication relative to similar precincts, with comparable eradication histories, that were not eradicated that year. It therefore cannot evaluate the compounded effect of past eradication, nor how five decades of eradication have shaped the relationship between these communities and the state. Over decades, eradication has likely contributed to the political and social marginalization of com-

munities that were already vulnerable and who lived in the peripheries of crime.

Beyond Mexico, the results speak to the electoral consequences of eradication in Latin America, home to 17 of the 22 countries the United States identified as major drug transit or drug-producing countries for fiscal year 2022. Where those harmed by eradication cannot contest it electorally, as in Mexico, eradication is likely to erode trust in the state and depress turnout. Elsewhere in the region, however, eradication has been vigorously contested. Two conditions have made this possible. First, eradication can overlap with existing political cleavages. In Colombia, where illegal crops financed the guerrillas, eradication was part of a highly contested and politicized counterinsurgency strategy (Abadie et al., 2014). Whether to pursue a militarized solution or alternative approaches, such as negotiating with the guerrillas, divided national politics. Candidates' positions on eradication followed their positions on the conflict, so voters could support or punish eradication electorally (Gélvez, 2024). Second, growers can build their own electoral vehicle to offer formal policy alternatives. In Bolivia, decades of union organizing and the quasi-legal status of coca, rooted in growers' indigenous identity, helped them build a successful party that championed their interests in national politics (Anria, 2013). In both countries, unlike in Mexico, the political opportunity structure allowed for electoral contestation of US-sponsored source country policy.

More broadly, the results in this paper speak to the domestic political consequences of policies on which foreign aid is conditioned. Policies inherently produce winners and losers. At their best, elections give losers a formal channel to contest the policies that harm them. When a foreign government conditions aid on a policy that imposes costs on some domestic groups, however, the recipient government must weigh its political response against the risk of losing the aid. Unless those harmed can impose sufficiently high political costs, the policy becomes inelastic to domestic preferences. This dynamic extends beyond aid conditioned on law enforcement. IMF loan conditions, for instance, target fiscal and economic policy, insulating it from electoral pressure in functioning democracies (Nooruddin & Simmons, 2006; Vreeland, 2003). Conditionality works because it makes it costlier for a government to abandon a policy than to keep harming some of its

domestic audiences. Weakened accountability toward those audiences is therefore not a side effect of conditional aid but the mechanism through which it operates.

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